

FROM BABYLON TO BOSTON

WHERE IT ALL STARTED

Before there were restaurants, hotels, or venues, there were taverns — and before those, we felt obligated to feed and shelter travelers. Hospitality did not begin with a business model. It began as a moral obligation.

The earliest recorded hospitality laws come from Babylon, nearly 4,000 years ago. According to research compiled by Star Tavern, Babylonian law — **ordered the death penalty for vendors who diluted beer**. It was a moral framework: the host's obligation to the guest was sacred, and any violations was treated accordingly.^[1] startavern.net

In ancient Greece, this concept had a name: *xenia* — the sacred law of hospitality. Hosts were expected to welcome strangers, offer food and shelter, and refrain from asking where they came from or the purpose of their visit; until after they had been fed. According to HRC International's historical overview of the industry, the Greeks dedicated spaces — the *lesche*, meaning a place for council or conversation, and the *phatnai*, which provided spaces for locals, traders, diplomats, and public officials.^[7] hrc-international.com

The Roman twist: Early Roman taverns had a bad reputation; and prominent men shunned them (in public). This did not stop the upper classes — they entered in disguise. *Outcasts and troublemakers often filled these taverns, keeping them alive with chaos. Even in ancient Rome, taverns drew everyone—proving humans have always been drawn to a good meal and lively company*

ANCIENT HOSPITALITY LAW

Babylonian law imposed the death penalty on tavern keepers who diluted beer — making good customer service a matter of life and death.

Source: *Star Tavern* — “What is a Tavern?” startavern.net

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Ancient civilizations with documented hospitality law: Babylon, Greece, Rome

HRC International, “History of the Hospitality Industry,” hrc-international.com



“Taverns and drinking establishments are almost as old as civilization itself. Some of the earliest records of tavern keeping involve Babylonian laws from nearly 4000 years ago.”

STAR TAVERN

startavern.net — “What Is a Tavern?”

Greek hospitality law (*xenia*): To refuse shelter to a traveler was a religious offense in ancient Greece. Being hospitable was a non-negotiable — it was divine duty enforced by Zeus himself in the role of Xenios, patron god of guests.